zhol · TEF Ignition 2026 · Workshop 2

# Early signals

## What the first ten answers to our one-minute survey say about disruptions in road freight

13 November 2026 · Survey open since 9 November · A small sample, read as direction, not proof



# The 2-minute pitch

## The problem

Hi, we’re zhol. Europe moves most of its freight by truck, and every country stops trucks by its own rules. On a typical week 14 to 17 countries ban trucks, each with its own hours and holidays, and strikes and blockades are called the evening before. A traffic office plans tomorrow at six in the evening and finds out at five in the morning, from a driver in a three-hour queue. At €100 an hour of legal waiting compensation, that is €300 for one truck; people who know the field put a stopped shipment at €300 to €1,000.

## What zhol does, unlike a map

Google Maps shows a driver the traffic right now. zhol tells the office tonight which of tomorrow’s loads will be hit, and what to do. The office sends its loads as Excel or a photo. AI agents read the official bans of seven countries so far, the dosing calendars and over 400 news articles a day, and a person checks every alert. Offices also share what their drivers see, news that is never online, and get everyone else’s in return. No map and no TMS has that network.

## Who pays, and how big

The owner pays per truck, €12 a month. When we asked, people put a fair price at €5 to €10, so our first ten offices pay €8. Europe has about 78,000 traffic offices, a market of about €230 million a year; ten percent of it is €24 million a year. We start in Northern Italy, a day from Milan, with 2,350 offices, and follow their lanes into Austria, Germany, Switzerland and France.

About 260 words, two minutes at a calm pace. Spoken, no slides at the table.

Why Europe

# Every European country stops trucks by its own rules.

One trip from Milan to Munich crosses three rulebooks. The information exists, but it is scattered, in many languages, and it changes overnight.

**Own bans.** On a typical week 14 to 17 countries ban trucks, each with its own hours and weight limits.

**Own holidays.** Italy, France, Switzerland, Austria and Germany stop trucks on different days.

**Strikes and blockades.** Called the evening before, by country and by sector; eight days in southern Italy cost over €400M.

**Office hours.** Offices check in office hours. Disruptions start at night and on holidays.

**We start in Northern Italy, a day from Milan, and follow our offices' lanes into Austria, Germany, Switzerland and France.**

Bans: weekly European truck-ban tracker, 2026. Road congestion alone costs the EU about €100bn a year, about 1% of GDP (European Commission); context, not our market.

How big

# A €230 million a year market, and we start with one region.

Europe

**78,000**

traffic offices in the EU, EEA and Switzerland, about €230M a year

Italy

**6,050**

offices with weekly lanes abroad, about €18.6M a year

We start here

**2,350**

offices in Northern Italy, 6 to 100 trucks, lanes over the Alps

Our plan, year 3

**250**

paying offices, about €0.8M a year

## What 10% would mean

**10% of Northern Italy.** 235 offices, about €0.7M a year.

**10% of Italy.** 605 offices, about €1.9M a year.

**10% of Europe.** 7,800 offices, about €24M a year.

One office pays about €3,080 a year: 21 trucks at €12 a month. Offices from Eurostat, KU Leuven for the ETF, CLECAT and Italy’s haulier register; details in docs/01. Ten percent is a scenario, not our plan.

# Who answered: ten people in three days

**2**

## traffic offices

Neither yet in our target segment of 6 to 100 trucks with weekly lanes abroad

**8**

## people who know the field

5 teach or research logistics, 3 work around it in forwarding, an association or consultancy

### The part of transport they know

Shippers 3 · rail and intermodal 2 · ports 1 · several 2 · road haulage 0

### How they reached the survey

Professors’ letters 7 · direct link 2 · a letter to a company 1

### Language

Italian 6 · English 4

**Also asked in person.** The team ran the same questions in person with more people in the field, and their answers were similar. Those answers are not entered here yet, so they are not counted in these numbers.

Answers since 9 Nov, 17:00 UTC; the team’s own test runs left out. Anonymous, reported only in aggregate.

# Four numbers from the eight who know the field

### Time an office spends checking each day

## 4 of 7

say 20 minutes or more, 3 of them over 40. Our bar for offices is 5 of 8.

### Shipments abroad changed per 100 in a month

## 8 of 8

say 2 or more, 3 say over 10. Our bar is 5 of 8.

### Cost to the carrier of a stopped shipment

## €300–1,000

the median of the 6 who gave a figure; 2 did not know. Our bar is €300.

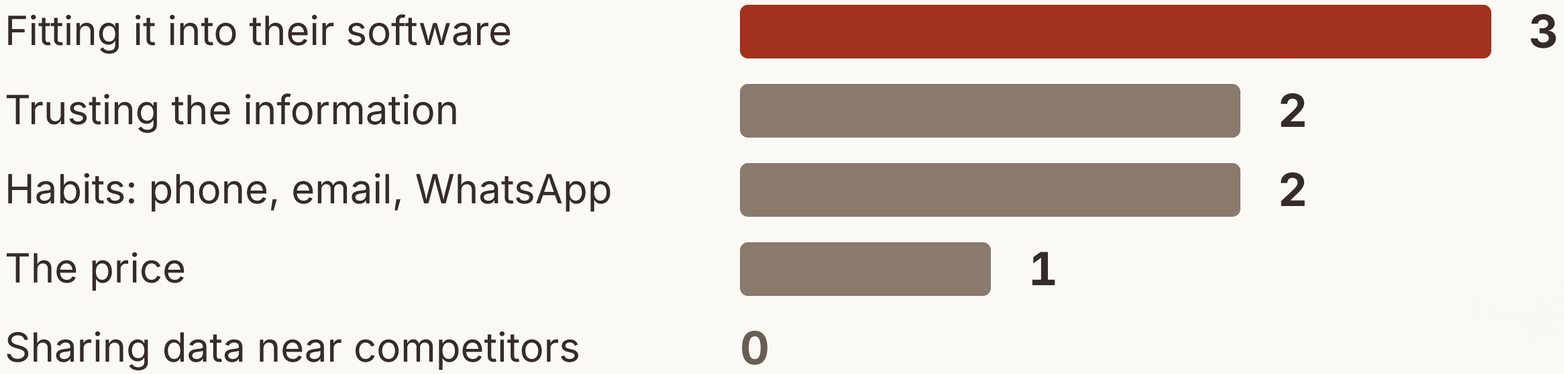
### A fair price per vehicle a month

## €5–10

the median of the 6 who gave a figure. Our founding price is €8.

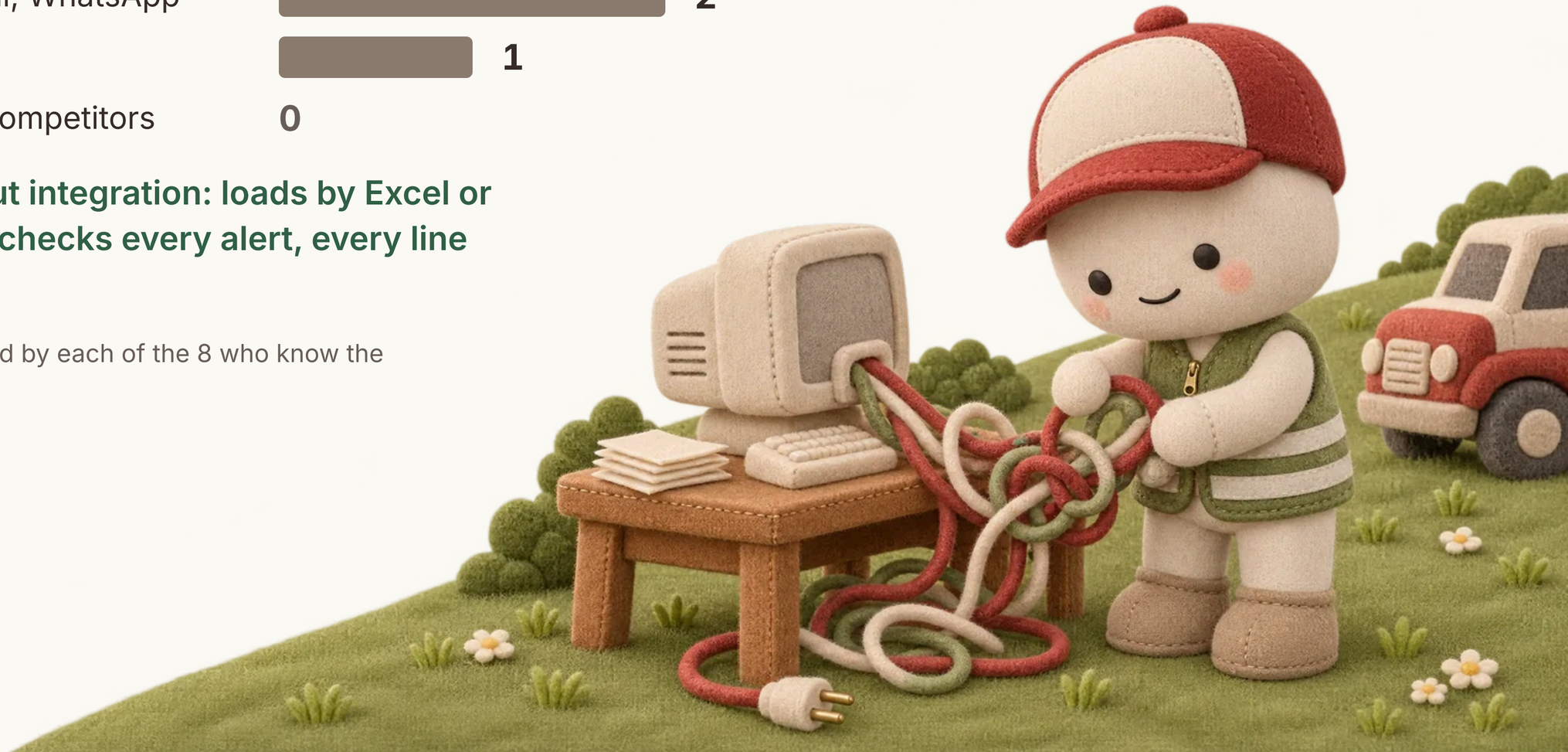
Answered from experience, not about their own desk. The 2 offices are too few to read and are left out here. Bars fixed before collection, docs/10.

# What would hold an office back




**So we start without integration: loads by Excel or a photo, a person checks every alert, every line cites its source.**

The main obstacle named by each of the 8 who know the field.



**Would offices share what their drivers see, if it stays anonymous?**

# 6 of 8

say most or some offices would. Of the eight, 3 said most, 3 said some, 2 said few.

That is the base of the shared watch. A driver stuck at the border tells the radar, and every office on that road knows before its trucks leave.

After answering, 4 asked to receive the results and 1 asked for a place in the shared network.



# One 20-truck office, projected from the answers

### Conservative

2 changed per 100 trips, €300 each, the lowest the experts gave

4 shipments changed a month

**€600**

a month avoidable, 2.5 times the €240 subscription

### Our model

4 per 100, 3 hours of waiting at €100 an hour, from docs/03

8 shipments hit a month

**€1,200**

a month avoidable, 5 times the subscription

### The experts' median

5.5 changed per 100 trips, €650 each

11 shipments changed a month

**€3,575**

a month avoidable, about 15 times the subscription

20 trucks, half on lanes abroad, 20 one-way trips each: 200 legs a month. An evening warning avoids half of the cost. A projection, not yet measured at an office.

# Across the 2,350 offices in our segment

**Cost an evening warning could avoid**

## €17–101M

a year, from the conservative case to the experts' median; our own model gives €34M

**What the segment would pay us**

## €4.5–6.8M

a year at €8 to €12 per truck a month, 20 trucks per office

**Price check**

The experts' median fair price is €5 to €10 per vehicle a month. Our €8 founding price sits inside it; the €12 standard price sits above it, so the interviews test it.

Offices with 6 to 100 trucks and weekly lanes abroad in northern Italy, between 1,170 and 3,500 (docs/09). Every input except the experts' answers is our assumption.

# A second segment to test: large operators on our corridors

| Company | Where | Published scale |
|---|---|---|
| Arcese | Basiano, Milan | 3,500+ people, 70 sites |
| DHL Freight Italy | Pozzuolo, Milan | 180 terminals, 40 countries |
| Raben Italy | Cornaredo, Milan | 300 people, 13 branches |
| GTS | Bari | Rail-road network |
| Torello | Montoro, Avellino | 2,770+ people, 40 sites |
| Nicolosi Trasporti | Catania | 110,000 m² storage |
| FERCAM | Bolzano | 1,460 people, 23 countries |
| GRUBER Logistics | Ora, South Tyrol | 750 trucks |
| LKW WALTER | Kufstein branch | 1.7m+ full loads a year |
| Gebrüder Weiss | Lauterach, Austria | 8,600 people, 180 sites |

What changes with them

## Same problem, a different buyer.

They buy per desk and want the alerts inside their own system.

**One desk.** One team on one lane, not the whole group.

**Budget.** Per desk, lane or flow, not per truck.

**Integration first.** Alerts arrive in their own TMS.

**Separate segment.** It does not add to the 2,350 offices.

Company facts from their official websites, checked by the team on 12 November 2026. None of these companies has answered our survey or spoken to us yet.

# A 200-truck pilot: only new, useful alerts count

200 trucks × half abroad × 20 one-way legs = **2,000 legs a month**

2,000 × 5% affected × €650 per changed load = **€65,000 of disruption cost a month**

| New, useful share of affected loads | Avoided a month | After the €1,600 subscription | Benefit to price |
|---|---|---|---|
| 5% | €1,625 | €25 | 1.0 times |
| 20% | €6,500 | €4,900 | 4.1 times |
| 35% | €11,375 | €9,775 | 7.1 times |

**The deciding number is how many alerts the office did not already know. The pilot logs exactly that: the first notice, the decision it changed, the cost avoided.**

Assumptions: 5% affected and €650 a load, near the experts’ medians; half of the cost avoidable; €8 a truck. At €12 the subscription is €2,400 and the 5% case loses money. Integration and onboarding not counted.

# Why zhol, and not what they already use

| What they use today | What it gives them | What it misses |
|---|---|---|
| Google Maps, Waze | Live traffic for a driver, right now | Tomorrow’s loads, truck bans, strikes ahead |
| Ban apps, the TIMOCOM portal | The calendar of bans | Nothing per load, nothing unplanned |
| TMS: Zucchetti, Dylog, Qargo | Tomorrow’s loads, in their system | No outside events at all |
| Telematics: Webfleet, Samsara | Where each truck is right now | What happens on the road tomorrow |
| Drivers’ WhatsApp groups, calls | Fast, free news from the road | Office hours, unchecked, no options |
| **zhol** | **Every load, the evening before** | **Planned and unplanned, checked, with options and cost** |

### History no one else has

A verified record of every disruption and what it did to real loads.

### Give news, get news

An office that shares what its drivers see gets what every other office’s drivers see. None of it is online.

### Their associations, their price

Sold through hauliers’ associations, at €12 a truck, under a telematics seat at €10–35.

An AI-first TMS such as Qargo is the most likely to add this; our answer is the history and the shared watch, which a single TMS cannot build alone. Sources in docs/02.

# How the MVP works, and how we reach offices

## One evening, in four steps

**16:00 · the office sends tomorrow's loads**
Excel, CSV or a photo, under two minutes. No software to install.

**17:30 and 20:00 · the engine checks each load**
Official bans of 7 countries, the Tyrol dosing calendar, the radar of 445 articles a day from 30 of 31 sources.

**Before sending · a person checks each event**
Target 90 seconds an event, 15 minutes a day per corridor set, about €1,000 a month.

**Evening · one WhatsApp message, only when hit**
The load, what happens, the options with their cost, and the source.

## Go-to-market

### We reach owners through people they already trust.

Then a free pilot proves the savings before anyone pays.

**Founder-led.** In Italian, to owners in the north: 200 named offices, 92 already listed.

**Associations.** FAI Conftrasporto, CNA Fita, Confartigianato Trasporti, with a member webinar and 15% off.

**Introductions.** Bocconi professors and the TEF network for the first pilots.

**Bulletin.** A free weekly Brenner and Alpine bulletin on WhatsApp.

**Later.** TMS and telematics partners, wholesale at €3–5 a truck.

**First 10 weeks: 200 contacts, 40 conversations, 12 interviews, 4 pilots, 2 paying offices.**

Cost to serve €1,230 a month at 10 offices (52% gross margin), €1,985 at 100 (92%). Human review is most of it. docs/03, docs/05.

# Testing with customers: what counts as success

| The question | How we measure it | Success if |
|---|---|---|
| Time saved | Minutes a day spent checking, timed on 3 pilot evenings | 20 min or more in 5 of 8 offices |
| Money saved | 4-week pilot ledger: only alerts the dispatcher confirms, events outside the calendar | €500 or more, and twice the price |
| Who signs, how much | Interview: who approves, the monthly amount they sign alone | Owner in 6 of 8, €200 a month or more |
| Price and package | Four prices per truck; alerts, alerts with options, or per shipment | €8 a truck acceptable; one package for 5 of 8 |
| Feasibility | Official sources, review time, correct alerts, missed problems | 70% official, 90 s, 80% correct, at most 1 missed |
| Conversion | Pilots that sign the founding offer | 2 of 4 |

**Fixed before we collect anything. The monthly statement leads with the benefit offices name most.**

Thresholds from docs/10. Financial plan in docs/13: base case break-even May 2029, €155k to raise; rebuilt after the pilots.

# Next: hear it from the offices themselves

### 1 · Introductions

Bocconi professors introduce us to hauliers with lanes over the Alps. Cold letters got no company reply yet.

### 2 · Interviews

Eight conversations with traffic offices, against the same bars.

### 3 · Pilots

Two offices, real restriction days, one WhatsApp message per hit load.

**The bars were fixed before we collected anything. If the offices miss them, we narrow the segment or move it.**

zhol.live · the survey stays open at zhol.live/survey, in five languages

